

Guide to Common Debate Motions

1. This House Supports/Welcomes/Opposes

Explanation:

These motions focus on endorsing or rejecting an idea, policy, or action. The emphasis is on **agreement or disagreement** with the subject, framed as a value-based motion.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Clarify the Motion:** Define the subject and explain the stance being taken.
- **Justify the Position:** Provide reasons for supporting or opposing the subject.
- **Highlight Benefits/Harms:** Show how the position leads to positive/negative outcomes.
- **Engage in Principles:** Address why the stance aligns with societal or moral values.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Challenge the Proposition:** Disagree with the framing or assumptions.
- **Highlight Contradictions:** Show flaws or inconsistencies in Prop's stance.
- **Propose Alternatives:** Present a better approach or policy if relevant.

Examples:

- This house supports universal basic income.
 - This house opposes the death penalty.
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2. This House Regrets

Explanation:

Regret motions evaluate whether a past action, policy, or event was undesirable. The debate focuses on assessing the consequences and inherent value of the subject.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Define Regret:** Specify what aspect of the subject is regrettable.
- **Highlight Negative Outcomes:** Emphasise harms caused by the subject.
- **Argue Alternatives:** Show how a different course would have been better.

- **Minimise Harms:** Argue that the negative impacts were minimal or unavoidable.
- **Challenge Alternatives:** Argue that Prop's proposed alternative would be worse.

Examples:

- This house regrets the rise of fast fashion.
 - This house regrets the proliferation of social media.
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3. This House Prefers X to Y

Explanation:

Preference motions compare two ideas, actions, or policies, requiring teams to argue why one is better than the other.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Justify the Preference:** Show why X is superior to Y.
- **Prove Benefits of X:** Highlight X's advantages.
- **Critique Y:** Demonstrate why Y is less desirable.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Defend Y:** Argue that Y is better than or equal to X.
- **Challenge X:** Undermine Prop's arguments in favour of X.
- **Highlight Trade-offs:** Show why X's benefits do not justify preferring it.

Examples:

- This house prefers economic growth to environmental preservation.
 - This house prefers private healthcare to public healthcare.
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4. This House Would

Explanation:

These motions require Prop to argue in favour of taking a specific action or implementing a policy.

- **Highlight Benefits:** Show the positive outcomes of implementing the action.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Defend the Status Quo:** Argue that the current system is sufficient.
- **Challenge Feasibility:** Highlight practical difficulties or risks.
- **Highlight Harms:** Argue that the action causes more harm than good.

Examples:

- This house would legalise all drugs.
 - This house would impose a universal basic income.
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5. This House as X

Explanation:

Actor motions place the house in the position of a specific actor (e.g., a government, institution or individual) and require teams to debate what that actor should do.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Define the Role:** Clarify the actor's responsibilities and capabilities.
- **Prove Necessity:** Show why the actor must take the proposed action.
- **Highlight Positive Impacts:** Argue that the action aligns with the actor's duties and creates benefits.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Challenge the Role:** Argue that the actor is not the best suited to take the action.
- **Defend the Status Quo:** Show that the actor's current approach is better.
- **Highlight Harms:** Argue that the action undermines the actor's goals or causes harm.

Examples:

- This house, as the United Nations, would prioritise climate change over conflict resolution.
 - This house, as a developing country, would prioritise economic growth over environmental preservation.
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Value-based motions assessing whether a belief or idea is valid, desirable, or morally justifiable.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Define the Belief:** Provide clarity on what the belief entails.
- **Justify the Belief:** Argue why the belief is true, beneficial, or morally right.
- **Highlight Impacts:** Show how the belief positively affects society or principles.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Challenge the Belief:** Argue that it is false, harmful, or irrelevant.
- **Highlight Negative Impacts:** Show how the belief creates harm or unintended consequences.
- **Propose Alternatives:** Argue for a competing belief.

Examples:

- This house believes that social media does more harm than good.
 - This house believes that democracy is the best form of governance.
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7. This House Believes That X Should

Explanation:

Policy-based motions requiring teams to debate whether a specific actor (X) should take a particular action.

Proposition Burdens:

- **Define X and the Action:** Clarify the actor and the action being proposed.
- **Prove Necessity:** Show why the action is needed.
- **Highlight Benefits:** Argue the positive outcomes for X or others affected.
- **Moral and Practical Justifications:** Establish why the action is right and achievable.

Opposition Burdens:

- **Challenge Necessity:** Argue that the action is unnecessary or disproportionate.
- **Highlight Harms:** Argue that the action causes more harm than good.
- **Propose Alternatives:** Suggest better approaches or defend the status quo.

Examples:
